

I8 Esau

The firstborn twin who sold his birthright for a meal, lost his father's blessing, and still ran to embrace the brother who wronged him.

Esau was the elder twin son of Isaac and Rebekah, born red and hairy, with Jacob gripping his heel. He grew into a skilled hunter and his father's favorite. Coming in hungry one day, he traded his birthright for a bowl of red stew. Later Jacob took the blessing Isaac meant for Esau, and Esau swore to kill him. Yet twenty years later Esau ran to meet his brother and embraced him with tears. He became the father of the Edomites. Scripture remembers him as a warning against despising what is holy, but his story also shows a surprising grace.

At a glance

Name	Esau, probably "hairy"; also Edom, "red" (Genesis 25:25, 30)
Family	Elder twin of Jacob; Hittite wives and a daughter of Ishmael
Work	"A cunning hunter, a man of the field" (Genesis 25:27)
Key places	Beersheba, the land of Seir (Edom), Hebron (Mamre)
Key people	Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, Ishmael
Descendants	The Edomites (Genesis 36:1–43)
Main passages	Genesis 25:19–34; 27:1–28:9; 32:3–33:16; 36
New Testament	Romans 9:10–13; Hebrews 11:20; 12:16–17

"And Esau ran to meet him, and embraced him, and fell on his neck, and kissed him: and they wept."

Genesis 33:4, KJV

The life of Esau

Isaac's ages come from *Genesis* 25:26 and 35:28; Esau's age at marriage from *Genesis* 26:34. On the traditional chronology the twins were born c. 2006 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000–1700 BC.

Isaac age 60	● Born first Esau comes out "red, all over like an hairy garment," and his twin follows, holding his heel. <i>Genesis</i> 25:24–26
Grown	● A man of the field Esau becomes a skilled hunter. Isaac loves him for the game he brings home. <i>Genesis</i> 25:27–28
Coming in hungry	● Sells his birthright Faint from the field, Esau asks for Jacob's red stew. Jacob demands the birthright, and Esau swears it away. "Thus Esau despised his birthright." <i>Genesis</i> 25:29–34
Age 40	● Marries Hittite wives Esau marries Judith and Bashemath, and they become "a grief of mind" to his parents. <i>Genesis</i> 26:34–35
Isaac old and blind	● Loses the blessing Esau returns from hunting to find that Jacob has taken his blessing. He cries, "Bless me, even me also, O my father." <i>Genesis</i> 27:30–40
After the blessing	● Plots revenge Esau plans to kill Jacob after Isaac's death. Seeing that Canaanite wives displease his father, he also marries a daughter of Ishmael. <i>Genesis</i> 27:41; 28:6–9
Twenty years later	● Embraces Jacob Esau comes from Seir with four hundred men. Instead of attacking, he runs to Jacob, kisses him, and they weep together. <i>Genesis</i> 32:3–6; 33:1–16
Isaac age 180	● Buries his father Isaac dies at Mamre, and Esau and Jacob bury him together. Esau later settles in mount Seir. <i>Genesis</i> 35:27–29; 36:6–8

Key activities

Malachi 1:2–3 and Romans 9:13 say "Esau have I hated." Many read "hated" as a Hebrew way of saying "loved less" or "did not choose" (compare Genesis 29:30–31). Christians differ on whether Paul means the choice of individuals for salvation or of nations for a role in God's plan.

-
- 1 Hunted.** He became "a cunning hunter, a man of the field," his father's favorite. *Genesis 25:27–28*
 - 2 Traded his birthright.** He sold it for "bread and pottage of lentiles," saying, "What profit shall this birthright do to me?" *Genesis 25:29–34*
 - 3 Married outside the family.** His Hittite wives grieved Isaac and Rebekah. *Genesis 26:34–35*
 - 4 Wept for a lost blessing.** He "cried with a great and exceeding bitter cry" but could not undo it. *Genesis 27:34–38; Hebrews 12:17*
 - 5 Nursed a grudge.** He hated Jacob and planned to kill him once Isaac was dead. *Genesis 27:41*
 - 6 Tried to please his father.** He married Mahalath, Ishmael's daughter, because Canaanite wives displeased Isaac. *Genesis 28:6–9*
 - 7 Forgave his brother.** He ran to meet Jacob, embraced him, and said, "I have enough, my brother." *Genesis 33:4–9*
 - 8 Founded a nation.** His family grew into the Edomites of mount Seir. *Genesis 36:1–43*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Esau.

Old Testament

Genesis 36:1-43	"The generations of Esau, who is Edom"
Numbers 20:14-21	Edom refuses Israel passage
Deuteronomy 23:7	Do not abhor an Edomite, "for he is thy brother"
Obadiah 10	Edom's violence "against thy brother Jacob"
Malachi 1:2-3	"Yet I loved Jacob, And I hated Esau"

New Testament

Romans 9:10-13	God's choice "not of works, but of him that calleth"
Hebrews 11:20	Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau by faith
Hebrews 12:16-17	"For one morsel of meat sold his birthright"
Echo: Luke 15:20	A father runs to embrace his returning son

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Esau say about his birthright when he was hungry (Genesis 25:32)?
2. *Understand:* Esau had every reason for revenge. What do you think changed his heart by Genesis 33?
3. *Apply:* What "bowl of stew" tempts you to trade away what matters most?
4. *Apply:* Is there someone you need to meet with grace instead of a grudge?